

30 tips that give you an hour back every day

Shortcuts, apps, AI and systems. Thirty things you can try right now — half a page each, with the steps and what it saves.

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Thirty tips across shortcuts, apps, AI, workflow, communication and hardware.

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01 Ctrl+F: don't read the page, search it

Shortcuts · Browser

Ctrl + **F**

Looking for a specific piece of information on a long page? Ctrl+F and a few letters get you there in two seconds.

1. Press Ctrl+F (Cmd+F on Mac) — a small search box opens.
2. Type your search term. The page immediately highlights every match found.
3. Enter jumps to the next match, Shift+Enter to the previous one — no mouse, no scrolling.
4. Search for a short, unique fragment rather than a whole phrase. Search is literal, not smart.

Saves: ~5 min a day

02 Closed a tab by mistake? Ctrl+Shift+T brings it back

Shortcuts · Browser

Ctrl + **Shift** + **T**

Reopens the last closed tab — and pressing it again brings back the ones before it. Works for whole closed windows too.

1. Press Ctrl+Shift+T (Cmd+Shift+T on Mac). The last closed tab reopens at the same address.
2. Press it repeatedly: the browser keeps bringing back tabs, from most recent to oldest.
3. It works after a browser crash too — the next launch restores the entire window with every tab.
4. For anything older, open your history (Ctrl+H). The shortcut's memory isn't unlimited.

Saves: ~3 min a day

03 Delete word by word, not letter by letter

Shortcuts · Everywhere

Ctrl + **Backspace**

Ctrl+Backspace deletes the whole word to the left, Ctrl+Delete the whole word to the right. Typos disappear in one go.

1. Place your cursor right after the word you want to delete, or anywhere within it.
2. Ctrl+Backspace deletes the entire word to the left of the cursor, not just one letter.
3. Ctrl+Delete deletes the entire word to the right — useful when fixing text ahead of you.
4. On Mac, Option+Delete does the same. It's standard system behavior, not an app feature.

Saves: ~2 min a day

04 Win+Shift+S: a screen clip exactly the way you need it

Shortcuts · Windows

Win + **Shift** + **S**

Windows' most useful shortcut for screenshots — pick a region, a window, or the whole screen, and the shot lands right in your clipboard.

1. Press Win+Shift+S. The screen dims and a toolbar with selection modes appears at the top.
2. Choose the mode you need: rectangular selection, freeform, window, or full screen.
3. The shot is saved to your clipboard automatically — just Ctrl+V it wherever you need it.
4. Click the notification in the bottom-right corner to open the snip editor and mark it up.

Saves: ~4 min a day

05 Space bar: preview a file without opening an app

Shortcuts · macOS

Space

Select a file in Finder and press Space. PDFs, photos, video and spreadsheets appear instantly — no waiting for an app to launch.

1. In Finder, select the file and press Space. A large preview window opens.
2. Use the ← → arrow keys to flip through other files in the same folder without closing it.
3. Quick Look handles multi-page PDFs, photos, videos, spreadsheets and text documents.
4. Select multiple files at once and Space offers a grid view of all of them together.

Saves: ~5 min a day

06 Hold the space bar: your keyboard turns into a trackpad

Shortcuts · Mobile

Landing a finger right in the middle of a word is a lottery. Holding the space bar turns your keyboard into a touchpad for precise cursor movement.

1. While typing, hold down the space bar. The keyboard turns gray and becomes a sensitive surface.
2. Drag your finger left, right, up or down to move the cursor to match exactly.
3. Once the cursor is in the right spot, lift your finger and continue typing.
4. The gesture works on both iPhone and Android with Gboard, nearly identically.

Saves: ~3 min a day

07 Flash Fill: Excel finishes the pattern for you

Apps · Everywhere

Ctrl + **E**

Type one example into the next column — say, a name pulled from an email address — and Ctrl+E fills in the rest to match. No formulas.

1. In the column next to your source data, type the first result by hand, exactly as it should look.
2. Click back into that cell and press Ctrl+E. Excel infers the pattern and fills the rest.
3. Check the gray preview before confirming — with irregular data it can miss in places.
4. When Excel isn't sure, fill in a second example on another row and press Ctrl+E again.

Saves: ~20 min a week

08 Text replacement: type “addr” and the whole address pops out

Apps · macOS

macOS can replace short shortcuts with long text system-wide — in email, browser and chat alike. Set it up once, works everywhere.

1. Open System Settings → Keyboard → Text Replacements.
2. Click + and add an entry: a short shortcut on the left, the full text on the right.
3. The full text can span multiple lines — an entire signature, or complete billing details.
4. Choose shortcuts that wouldn't show up in ordinary text, so nothing unintended gets replaced.

Saves: ~10 min a day

09 Custom search shortcuts: “w query” searches Wikipedia

Apps · Browser

Teach your address bar to search specific sites directly — Wikipedia, Maps, your internal wiki. One letter, a space, your query.

1. Open Browser settings → Search engine → Manage search engines.
2. Add a new one: a name, the keyword you'll type (e.g. “w”), and a URL with %s where the query goes.
3. Test it: type “w Pomodoro” into the address bar and the browser jumps straight to the result.
4. Find the URL with %s by searching on the site and copying the resulting address.

Saves: ~4 min a day

10 Todoist: add a task in a single sentence

Apps · Everywhere

“every Monday at 10 #meetings p1” — Todoist picks up the date, recurrence, project and priority straight from the text.

1. Type the whole sentence straight into the task name, not just a bare label.
2. The # symbol introduces a project, / a sub-project, @ a label, and p1 to p4 a priority.
3. Dates with times are recognized from common phrases: “tomorrow”, “next Tuesday”, “in two weeks”.
4. Before saving, glance at the preview under the field — it shows how Todoist read the sentence.

Saves: ~5 min a day

11 Voice capture: write down an idea even when you can't type

Apps · Mobile

In the car, on a walk, with your hands full of groceries: “Hey Siri, add...” and the thought is in the system.

1. For quick tasks, use a direct command: “Add milk to my shopping list.”
2. For reminders with a time attached: “Remind me tomorrow at 9 to call the doctor.”
3. For longer thoughts, use a voice memo — modern note apps transcribe it to text right away.
4. Activate the assistant by calling out or holding a button — it works on a locked phone too.

Saves: ~5 min a day

12 PowerToys Run: a launcher like Spotlight on the Mac

Apps · Windows

Alt + **Space**

Alt+Space opens a bar that launches apps, finds files, does math and converts units. The Start menu can retire.

1. Install PowerToys from Microsoft and enable the PowerToys Run module in its settings.
2. Press Alt+Space. A simple search bar appears on screen.
3. Type an app name, a file name, or a math expression such as “2490*0.79”.
4. Cycle through results with the arrows and confirm with Enter; the first is usually right.

Saves: ~5 min a day

13 Role, context, task, format: anatomy of a prompt

AI · Everywhere

The quality of an answer is decided in the request, not in the choice of model. A good prompt holds four parts, each doing its own job.

1. Role sets the perspective: “You’re an experienced commercial lawyer.” It filters what stays in.
2. Context is the one thing the model doesn’t know — who it’s for, what happened, your constraints.
3. Task needs a verb and a clear scope. “List the risks”, not “take a look at this”.
4. Format: length, structure, tone. And above all, say what you don’t want too.

Saves: ~30 min a day

14 Custom instructions: set up AI once, it applies forever

AI · Everywhere

Standing instructions apply in every new conversation. A working set has four blocks — keep them in this order, the model reads top to bottom.

1. Who you are: two to four sentences on profession, field and level. “I’m a manager” does almost nothing.
2. How you want answers: structure and length in numbers — how many bullets, what comes first.
3. What tone: describe it through a relationship. “Write like a colleague with no time for pleasantries.”
4. What never to do: three to six prohibitions. They work best because they’re clearly checkable.

Saves: ~15 min a day

15 A long document? Let AI make an excerpt with page numbers

AI · Everywhere

Let the model decide the format and you get flowing prose. Prescribe the format and you get a document you can actually work from.

1. Say who will read the excerpt and why. Without that the model can't pick what's relevant.
2. Prescribe the structure: what it's about, main points with pages, figures, deadlines by date.
3. Add the point “what the document does NOT address, even though you'd expect it to”. Usually the most valuable.
4. Ban guessing: “where you're not sure of the location, write location not determined”.

Saves: ~30–90 min per document

16 AI writes the first draft, you write the final one

AI · Everywhere

Given only the incoming message, the model guesses predictably wrong. A good request holds four things: who — what I want — tone — length.

1. Who: the relationship type, not a name. A longtime client, a colleague two levels up, an opposing party.
2. What I want: the recipient's outcome, not the topic. The single strongest line in the brief.
3. Tone: one or two precise words. “Matter-of-fact, no apologies.” Avoid “professional”.
4. Length: “max 6 sentences”. Without it the model writes long. And then: AI drafts, you send.

Saves: ~30 min a day

17 From a meeting recording to notes with tasks in a minute

AI · Everywhere

Notes need to be structured by content type, not by the order things were said. Three categories are enough — kept strictly separate.

1. Decisions: only what was actually closed — one declarative sentence, who decided, what was weighed.
2. Tasks as a table: task | owner (one name, never “the team”) | deadline | where it comes from.
3. Open items: what was discussed with no conclusion. The most valuable part of the notes.
4. Ban guessing: “where no deadline was stated, write DEADLINE NOT STATED, don't invent one”.

Saves: ~30 min per meeting

18 AI makes things up with total confidence. Verify it

AI · Everywhere

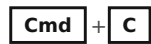
A rule journalists developed long before AI existed: a key claim needs two independent sources, everything else needs one.

1. A key claim is one the conclusion rests on, or that leads to a decision about money. Usually three to five, not thirty.
2. Independent means the figure arose through two paths that don't know about each other. Two articles from one press release are one source.
3. Follow the hierarchy: a primary source — the study, official statistics, the full text — is always best.
4. Actually open the links. The model sometimes cites a page the claim isn't on at all.

Saves: reputation

19 Copy text right out of images and photos

AI · macOS



macOS can select text in a photo or screenshot just like regular text. Grab a phone number off a photo of a business card in two clicks.

1. Open the image in Preview, in Photos, or just look at it in Quick Look.
2. Hover your cursor over text in the image — it switches from an arrow to a text cursor.
3. Select the passage by dragging, press Cmd+C and paste it wherever you need it.
4. Recognition runs on the device and the image is never sent anywhere — safer than online services.

Saves: ~5 min a week

20 Three tasks for the day: pick in the morning, check in the evening

Workflow · Everywhere

Not a list of twenty items, but three things that absolutely must get done today. Everything else is a bonus.

1. In the morning — or better, the evening before — pick three tasks. No more.
2. The criterion: if only these three get done today, it was a good day, even if the rest goes untouched.
3. Put the biggest of the three first, while you still have the most energy and focus.
4. In the evening, two minutes of review, and move anything unfinished to a specific day, not back to the list.

Saves: ~1 h a day

21 The two-minute rule for your inbox

Workflow · Everywhere

Anything that takes less than two minutes, do right when you read it. Longer things go to your task list — and archive the email.

1. Only open an email when you actually have time to do something about it.
2. Under two minutes — a short reply, a forward, a confirmation — handle it now and archive it.
3. Over two minutes, create a task with a deadline and archive the email. It doesn't stay as a reminder.
4. The goal is an inbox that ends up empty: every message already has its place.

Saves: ~20 min a day

22 Block off calendar time for focused work

Workflow · Everywhere

An empty calendar is an invitation to meetings. Block off your mornings for deep work before someone else does it for you.

1. At the start of the week, pick two or three 90-minute blocks for your most important work.
2. Create them as real calendar events, not just a note off to the side.
3. Name the block specifically: “Q4 Budget Draft”, not a generic “Focus time”.
4. Set the status to Busy — that's what makes colleagues' scheduling tools skip past it.

Saves: ~2 h a week

23 The weekly review: 30 minutes that run your whole week

Workflow · Everywhere

On Friday or Sunday, go through your calendar, tasks and notes. Close out loose ends, plan three priorities — and Monday starts with clarity.

1. Pick a fixed time and stick to it: Friday around 3 p.m. or Sunday evening, 30 minutes uninterrupted.
2. Review last week, the upcoming calendar, and your entire task manager across all projects.
3. Pick three priorities for the week. If only those three got done, was it a good week?
4. Give the priorities specific blocks in your calendar, not just an entry on a task list.

Saves: ~30 min a week

24 Grayscale mode: a colorless phone is half as tempting

Workflow · Mobile

Grayscale turns your phone into a tool instead of a dopamine machine. Ideal for focus blocks.

1. iOS: Accessibility → Display & Text Size → Color Filters → Grayscale.
2. Android: Accessibility → Color correction → Grayscale (location varies by manufacturer).
3. Add a toggle to your quick settings, or a triple-click shortcut on the side button.
4. Use grayscale deliberately during focus blocks and switch back for photos and navigation.

Saves: ~30 min a day

25 30 seconds to undo a sent email

Communication · Gmail

Gmail can “hold” sending for up to 30 seconds. A typo in the recipient or a forgotten attachment stops being a disaster.

1. Open Settings → See all settings.
2. In the General section, find Undo Send and set 30 seconds, the maximum available.
3. Save your changes with the button at the bottom of the page.
4. After every send, an Undo bar appears in the bottom left — the email returns to drafts.

Saves: reputation

26 Slack: Ctrl+K jumps to any channel or teammate

Communication · Slack

Ctrl + **K**

The quick switcher finds a channel, a message or a person in a few keystrokes. Slack's single most important shortcut.

1. Press Ctrl+K (Cmd+K on a Mac) anywhere in Slack — no need to be in a particular channel.
2. Type part of a channel name or a colleague's name. It suggests matches after a few letters.
3. Use the arrow keys to pick from the suggestions and press Enter. Slack takes you straight there.
4. It finds private group conversations too — a universal entry point into anything in Slack.

Saves: ~5 min a day

27 Outlook rules: let your inbox sort itself

Communication · Outlook

Automatic rules move system notifications, reports and CCs into folders. Your inbox stays reserved for messages that actually need you.

1. Right-click a message and choose Rules → Create Rule...
2. Set the condition: most often the sender, or keywords in the subject line.
3. Choose “move to folder” as the action; you can create the folder right in that step.
4. Route system notifications into one catch-all folder and check it once a day in a batch.

Saves: ~10 min a day

28 Filter your Teams activity down to just @mentions

Communication · Teams

The Activity feed can show only messages where someone mentioned you. Everything else is mostly noise.

1. Open Activity in the Teams left sidebar.
2. Click the filter at the top of the panel and choose @Mentions.
3. Go through them and reply right away. It's exactly what someone is waiting on from you.
4. Handle the rest of the activity in batches, once or twice a day at a set time.

Saves: ~10 min a day

29 Noise-cancelling headphones: focus and a signal, both at once

Hardware · Everywhere

ANC headphones solve two problems at once: ambient noise, and coworkers who can't tell you don't want to be disturbed.

1. Choose headphones with active noise cancellation (ANC), not just physical isolation.
2. Prepare playlists by work mode: instrumental music or white noise with no lyrics for deep focus.
3. Treat headphones on your head as a visual “do not disturb” signal — tell your team once.
4. Charge them when you're not using them anyway. Dead headphones are why people give up the habit.

Saves: ~30 min a day

30 Top edge of your monitor at eye level

Hardware · Everywhere

A neck that hurts from a monitor set too low. A stand or arm for a few dollars fixes years of discomfort.

1. The top edge should be roughly at eye level when you sit upright, at arm's length from the screen.
2. Raise your laptop on a stand. A sturdy box or thick books work too, as long as they're stable.
3. Connect an external keyboard and mouse so your hands stay in a natural position at elbow level.
4. Even the ideal position is harmful without movement — stand and stretch roughly once an hour.

Saves: healthy back

This is thirty out of several hundred

The whole handbook is free on the site and gets updated every day. Here are three places to go next.

productive.tips/prirucka

The complete productivity handbook — systems, habits and tools in one place, free.

productive.tips/nastroje/kviz

Not sure where to start? The quiz picks a system that fits you in two minutes.

productive.tips/newsletter

One tip a week — two minutes to read, hours saved. Unsubscribe with one click.

Josef Pavlovic

productive.tips